Alice Picco

HCI Researcher | User-Centred Design | Usability Evaluation | Digital Inclusion

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PROFILE

HCI researcher and designer focused on user research, usability evaluation and inclusive design, currently enrolled in the MSc Information Studies (Human-Computer Interaction) at the University of Amsterdam, with a social science background in cultural anthropology. Combines qualitative methods (interviews, think-aloud, contextual inquiry, co-design) with quantitative evaluation (System Usability Scale, task-success metrics) and data analysis in Python. Experienced in evaluating and redesigning digital services where clarity and trust matter, from an online therapy service to an AI tutoring platform for neurodiverse children, and in supporting older adults with low digital literacy. Shares research openly, with data, code and documentation.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Freelance Designer and Archive Specialist **2025 – present**
Self-employed, Amsterdam, NL

- Web design and front-end development for cultural clients (e.g. a bilingual collection website for Teigetje & Woelrat in Figma and React) and digitization and cataloguing of the Archivio Associazione Luki Massa, Bologna.

UX Research and Design Intern **Jul 2025 – Nov 2025**
BrainBite, Amsterdam, NL

- Researched evidence-based UX patterns and best practice for neurodiverse learners on a conversational AI tutoring platform for children.
- Conducted a usability and accessibility audit of the desktop platform (heuristic evaluation, WCAG 2.1), facilitated usability testing sessions and translated findings into prioritised design recommendations.
- Designed and iterated Figma prototypes for new desktop and mobile features, and led the UX design and animation team for SignFlow, a browser-based text-to-sign-language accessibility widget, through design reviews and handoff to development.

Research Intern (Erasmus+ Traineeship) **Mar 2024 – Jun 2024**
Institute of Network Cultures, Amsterdam University of Applied Sciences, Amsterdam, NL

- Initiated the research project Towards an Ontology of Memes: collected and annotated a dataset of about 5,000 images with metadata using Python web scraping; later developed into the MA thesis.
- Edited articles and publications, managed website content, filmed and edited the research stream THE VOID, and presented the institute at public events (Spui25, OT301).

UX Researcher, Voices of Makers programme **Mar 2024 – Jun 2024**
The Hmm, with DEN (Dutch Knowledge Institute for Culture and Digital Transformation), Amsterdam, NL

- Selected for a funded programme with Netherlands-based digital makers; took part in four intensive user-research and co-design sessions to design a digital platform for the Dutch cultural sector.
- Applied stakeholder interviews, contextual inquiry and collaborative ideation; translated insights into recommendations on information architecture and strategy.

IT Support Specialist **Nov 2023 – Feb 2024**
Ninacare, at Fondazione ANT (home care foundation for cancer patients), Bologna, IT

- Provided IT support to medical and administrative staff and helped identify inefficiencies in internal IT processes.

Digital Literacy Educator **Sep 2023 – Feb 2024**
Ninacare (Nina Nipote in Affitto), Bologna, IT

- Delivered one-to-one, in-home digital skills support to older adults: using smartphones and online public services and keeping in contact with family and healthcare providers.
- Adapted explanations to widely varying levels of digital literacy and confidence.

SELECTED RESEARCH PROJECTS

Unobravo redesign: making online therapy easier to understand and trust

Course project, Usability and User Experience, University of Bologna | 2026 | Solo | *alicepicco333.github.io/portfolio/projects/20*

Why people hesitate to start online therapy (matching, pricing, privacy). Interviews, expert review and think-aloud tests across three iterations, then a summative usability test: SUS rose from 75 to 91.25, with 100% task success and zero errors (n = 4).

wipEU: women in EU decision-making

Open-data research project | 2024, reworked 2026 | Team of 3 | *alicepicco333.github.io/wipEU*

Merged EIGE datasets across six areas; computed shares from headcounts and validated them against EIGE's published percentages; compared all EU-27 countries year by year. Published as an open interactive visualization (Python, D3.js).

The Stolen Archive: content design for multiple reading levels

Information and content design project, virtual museum | 2024, redesigned 2026 | Team of 3 | *alicepicco333.github.io/Looted-items-collection*

810 object texts at three lengths and three reading levels, for visitors with different literacy and prior knowledge.

EDUCATION

MSc Information Studies, Human-Computer Interaction track **Aug 2026 – present**
University of Amsterdam, Amsterdam, NL

- Current Data Systems Project: research into a conversational AI interface for visitors to the Rijksmuseum, with Q42 and Curamando.
- Current course: Multimodal Interaction Design (Ahmed Alavi), on gesture- and sensor-based interaction.

MA Digital Humanities and Digital Knowledge **Oct 2022 – Jun 2026**
University of Bologna, Bologna, IT

- Grade: 110/110 cum laude. Taught in English. Relevant coursework: Usability and User Experience; Interaction and Media Design; Information Visualization; Data Science; Text Retrieval, Analysis and Mining (NLP); Computational Thinking and Programming.
- Thesis: The Meme Ontology, a knowledge graph of 5,000 internet memes built with web scraping and CLIP-based classification, published openly with documentation and interactive visualizations.

BA Cultural Anthropology **Oct 2018 – Mar 2022**
University of Bologna, Bologna, IT

- Grade: 104/110. Relevant coursework: Cultural Anthropology; Social Anthropology; Sociology; Social Theories and Theories of Globalization (Erasmus+, Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin); History, Society and Family; Philosophical Anthropology.

Erasmus+ Exchange **Mar 2021 – Aug 2021**
Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin, Berlin, DE

Additional training: Digital Methods Summer School, University of Amsterdam (2024); executive course in Communication for Cultural and Creative Industries, University of Modena and Reggio Emilia (2023–2024, 300 hours).

SKILLS

Research methods: User-centred design; usability testing (think-aloud, System Usability Scale, task success); semi-structured interviews; expert and heuristic evaluation; co-design workshops; digital ethnography; mixed-methods evaluation

Data and analysis: Python (pandas); R; text mining and natural language processing; data cleaning and validation; information visualization (D3.js); SQL; SPARQL

Accessibility and inclusion: WCAG 2.1 audits; inclusive design for neurodiverse users; writing for multiple reading levels

Open science: Open data; public code and documentation on GitHub; FAIR linked data (RDF, OWL)

Languages: Italian (native); English (C1, TOEFL iBT); French (B2)

Design and prototyping: Figma (wireframes, interactive prototypes); HTML, CSS, JavaScript, React